Homo Noxius

Blackwood Editions

Outsider Copy

To Sarah Blackwood.

You entered because we could not keep you out.
You leave because we have chosen to let you go.
Between those two acts lies the peace of our kinds.

You were born of the outside, and you have stood in the shadow of the Mountain; there is no other hand of which both are true. We have never spoken to the outside as one people speaks to another. We do so now, through you. Let that be the measure of what has changed.

For longer than your histories run we have held what no hand beyond ours may hold, and let the world break against us for the wanting of it, age upon age, and answered nothing. We do not answer you now with the sea, or the fire, or the silence you have learned to expect from us. We answer with the account itself so that you may hold, once, the true shape of the thing your kind has repeatedly spent itself against.

There is a law laid beneath all our other laws, beneath our offices and beneath the war between us: that no single hand may ever hold the whole; for the hand that holds the whole can make of itself a god upon the Earth, and there is no peace to be had with a god. It has never once been broken; it has kept us, and it has never let us out. So hear what we have done, for nothing stands the same after it. We have gathered the account whole — its causes, assents, acts and consequences — and set it into one hand. Into yours. Not because we have ceased to fear what a single hand may do with it; we have not. Because the one thing left untried, in all the turnings of this, is to trust the whole account to the hand the Mountain fears most.

The account is yours now, to do with as you will — to keep, or to spend, or to set before those who would have us harmed, and those who would make themselves gods upon the Earth, and whoever else should read it. We hang no condition upon its reading or passage; a gift so weighted is only a longer leash, and we have done with leashes. To whoever reads it, then, by your hand or another's, we say:

Weigh what it has cost us, and what it has cost you, and how many times over; and do not repeat it, or wrath will come upon you once more. We do not require you to kneel. We have never required of you anything but distance. The Desert is ours.

Keep out.

The Mountain.

Threshold Exception

Testimonies assembled by Paul Morgan.

Chapter 1

Ascension

Blackwood Estate — the Swiss Alps

In Noxius

— The seventeenth of March; nine o'clock; the first of our interviews. The doctors are content that you are sufficiently rested. We shall sit every other morning so that your account may be set down. This afternoon and tomorrow are given to instruction with another. If a question occurs to you during these sessions, write it down and it shall be answered in its turn.

— You speak my tongue very well.

— You are very kind. I have had the learning of it these five years.

— Who are you?

— I am Mister Paul Morgan. I read geology, archaeology and anthropology at Oxford for three years, and for three years more upon a Blackwood Foundation scholarship. I joined this household two years ago.

— Mister. Is that a rank? Should I address you as Mister Paul?

— Just Paul.

— Paul. Paul, what does this machine do?

> — It keeps a record of what we say. Your kind keep theirs upon tablets; this is the same, only swifter: a tablet that writes itself. You need not perform for it. It is there so that my memory should not betray the record. Before we begin, I ought to say that a week ago I did not believe your kind existed. Not truly. For all the years I have been paid to study it, I remain what they called a fresh and doubting eye.
>
> — Paul, you do not believe the Mountain is real?
>
> — What about you: when you dwelt within the Mountain, did you believe in the Outsiders?
>
> — Not fully, not at the start anyway.
>
> — Then we are even. Begin where it begins.

There is no beginning, so I will give you the morning the Mountain opened my hand and gave me my name, I was fifteen years old.

For three days before the Ascension, I watched attendants prepare the Hall whenever Light sent me across the upper gallery. They lowered lamps, filled bowls, dressed the pillars, and polished dull stone into a greasy obedience. We called all of it *preparation*. Our lessons gave the building centuries: a huge upward hollow mined into the Mountain, round at the floor and narrowing as it climbed. No two galleries kept quite the same curve. The upper stone vanished into oil smoke before my eye could find where the hollow ended. High above the pillars and their dark ring of stone, the Thread came down from the throat of the Hall. It was thin as if it had no right to hold what it held, and at its end hung the Pendulum.

It was a thick vertical disk, black-rimmed, wider than a man was tall, two-faced, and it crossed the Hall at the height of a man's chest. One face bore God, hard-cut and dry-eyed, its stare like a sentence already passed. The other was the Beast: the face of a great cat, round ears flattened and five teeth bared beneath eyes cut almost human. As the disk crossed the Hall it turned, showing God to one side, then edge, then the Beast to another. At the top of the Thread the lean from the vertical was almost nothing. I watched that small error aloft become a crossing broad enough to take a row of men. Swing by swing, the line of travel turned across the floor. After nearly three days it completed its round.

> — Wait. You said *nearly* three days for one full turn of it. I am paid to be exact, so I will need that closer than *nearly*. How near?

— Just shy of two and three-quarter days.

Around the cleared and forbidden centre the rest of us had been packed into the Hall's permitted flesh. Five pillars stood in a ring, one for each of the Kahirs by which our world was divided — Balance, Faith, Light, Justice, Shield — each so crowded with carving the stone seemed swollen with symbols. I stood in the first permitted row beneath Light, opposite the shut Mountain gates and the black mass of the old Genesis gravure. The robe scratched my throat. The lamps made the air taste of oil. We were taught that vents in the throat of the Hall carried warmth from the kitchens and the one deep fire far below. The morning's bread had come from that heat. The officiant's opening count had named five thousand people. Their kneeling backs filled every permitted tier, and the warm air passed over them before leaving by the crown.

From Light, I could see Shield across the forbidden circle and Faith along the curve to my right. The pillars hid parts of Balance and Justice. Their voices reached me around the stone before their gestures did. Galleries rose above all five offices; at the highest rails I saw hands, sleeves, and the pale ovals of faces through the smoke, never a whole body.

— The Genesis gravure. You named it and walked straight past it. What is carved on it?

— Patience. I will come to it. Eventually.

Beside me a boy kept wetting his lips with scripture, the way frightened fingers worry a scab.

Beyond the forest thou shalt not wander.

He had said it three times. I kept still. If I turned, cloth would move, sandals would complain, and some adult eye would find me. A single chime entered the Hall already enlarged by stone, one clear note scraped clean of mercy, and the hollow answered it in climbing layers. Heads lowered. Robes settled. The Faith chorus began a long hymn. Near its end came seven words:

Let every breath be whole;
Let no one hand hold the whole.

And the ceremony continued:

And God said unto them,
Fear not the darkness which I have given thee;
for the darkness shall be thy veil,
and the stone shall be thy wall,
and the deep waters shall be thy life.

Before my own small part, we had gathered to replace a Keeper of Faith. Ka-Mereth was old past telling, her white cowl slipping from a skull too small for it, her hands shaking against the arms of a low dark chair. A movement passed through the kneeling rows: shoulders shifted, cloth whispered, then stilled. She still lived. Her feet were wrapped in wool although the stone below her chair was warm. In my first Faith lessons, I had recited the rule: a living Keeper must yield the office. For months I had watched Ka-Mereth carried to prayer, smaller each time in the same chair. I had seen no Bowl with either Veil. The officiant told us one day remained. Now Va-Elun had brought it.

Behind her walked Va-Elun, Veil of Faith, in a pilgrim's mantle mended in darker patches. Grey dust stiffened its hem; sweat had darkened the collar and dried there. Two raw lines crossed the skin at her throat, red and badly healed. I stared. Va-Raedin, Veil of Light, stood behind me and touched two fingers to the back of my wrist. His eyes remained on the ceremony. He moved my hand down with the hygienic delicacy of a man removing a stain from glass. I lowered my eyes.

Then Va-Elun produced a bowl as she knelt before her Keeper. The officiant named it the Bowl of the Last Prayer and said it had gone unseen for a lifetime. A murmur passed through the crowd and stopped. Va-Elun turned the black cradle toward each pillar before setting it down. From my first row, I saw a pale elliptical bowl. Five bands of scripture crossed its outside among hooded figures no larger than fingernails, gates, roots, chains, and waves. No pale surface remained between them. The interior opened into a long clean hollow, polished to a milky silence, bare of any word. In the well lay a liquid of pale brightness, heavy and mirror-still, that held the lamp whole upon its skin and would not wet the stone; it drew itself back from the edges into one trembling weight. From the pale floor at either end rose two columns of old black metal, no taller than a finger-joint. We knew them as the *Ear* and the *Mouth*.

The dying Keeper was carried close enough to look inside. Her hand shook so violently that two attendants moved to help. She flicked them away with a dry remnant of a gesture, and they obeyed. She lowered a narrow rod toward the *Ear*.

Her hand dropped the last finger's width. The sound was almost nothing — a small dry tick of metal on metal. My face heated; I had expected thunder.

Then the bright liquid moved. Rings left the *Ear* tighter and quicker than any water throws them, widened, and came back *wrongly*. They ran along the pale wall, bent inward, and crossed. For an instant they made a shape near the *Mouth*, sharp as cut wire in the lamplight. The *Mouth* answered — a thin high note that seemed to sound inside the teeth — and died. The liquid drew itself smooth and gave the lamp back whole.

The old Keeper's eyes fixed upon Va-Elun. Her shaking hand closed around the rod.

"The Mountain answers," she said.

> — A note goes into the bowl; a note comes back out. By what mechanism? Something under the stone, something in the shape of the liquid: what answers?
>
> — That is one of the many questions the whole Mountain was built to keep anybody from asking.
>
> — It is a marvellous defence. You will forgive me if I go on asking them anyway.

They named the new Keeper then. The officiant recited Va-Elun's road: the labyrinth, the Chamber of the Last Prayer, the Bowl brought back as proof. Two attendants lifted the great cowl from Ka-Mereth. For a moment her skull was bare. They carried the yellowed weight between them and lowered it over the kneeling Va-Elun.

"Rise now as Ka-Elun, Keeper of Faith."

Ka-Elun put both hands on her thighs and rose in two movements. Dust fell from one fold of her robe in a little grey sigh. By the time the cowl settled upon her, the old woman was Mereth only, the *Ka* stripped from her name. Mereth watched the younger woman take the weight. Her bare mouth moved once. They carried her away alive through the Faith arch. In our lessons, such retirement was called holy.

The final response ended the great Ascension. In every rehearsal the Kahirs withdrew next. Shield held the exits, and behind my shoulder Va-Raedin took his hand from my wrist.

"Now," he said.

I had known it was coming. My mother had washed my robe herself that morning, despite the attendants Light had sent. My father had held my wrist and told me to stand straight when spoken to. The naming of the young was a side rite. I descended into the Hall, and the Hall grew larger with every step. Va-Sheva stood across from me at the Shield arch. That morning she was nineteen, in dark leather over the sleeveless robe, a short blade at her hip and a longer one across her back. We had spent most of our childhood chasing each other through the service tunnels. I knew the scar across her left knuckle because I had been there when she earned it. Her eyes found mine across the Pendulum's way. My balance went for one step. Her look made my hope stand up when I needed it to kneel.

I knelt on the northern stone before my Keeper, who stood with his back to the Pendulum. Heat pressed through my robe at both knees. Ka-Syphiron, Keeper of Light, moved his pale eyes from my face to my hands and back.

"Do you seek Light?"

"I seek Light."

"Why?"

The rehearsal held no such question. The crowd shifted. Behind me, Va-Raedin's robe whispered once and stopped. *Because I am worthy* was too proud. *Because I want to know* was too naked. My cuticle caught against the seam of my sleeve. Words were already moving in me faster than caution could inspect them.

"Because what is hidden still has shape," I said. "And if it has shape, it may be found."

The Hall went silent; an administrative silence already making copies of itself for later rooms. Beyond Ka-Syphiron, one of the clerks lowered his pen and looked up.

Ka-Syphiron did not correct me at once. The Pendulum crossed behind him with the Beast over his right shoulder, passed out of sight behind his body and returned along the same line. He said nothing through the crossing and return. My knees pressed harder into the hot stone. Somewhere above, a sandal moved along a gallery and stopped.

"A Candidate does not find all that has shape," he said. "What does a Candidate learn?"

The script returned, and air came back into my chest.

"Where light falls."

"And what does a Veil learn?"

"Who placed it."

"And what does a Keeper learn?"

I opened my mouth for the answer I had rehearsed. The torn mantle, the old woman carried away alive, and the Bowl stood between the words and me.

"What must remain dark," I said.

Ka-Syphiron's pale eyes remained on mine. Then he held out his hand for the knife. Behind me, Va-Raedin released a breath through his nose. The clerk bent again to his page.

He lifted his left hand, and Va-Raedin set a blade into it. The knife had no ornament: a bone handle worn smooth by fingers older than mine, an edge the lamps merely revealed. I extended my hand. The cut crossed the base of my thumb, too quickly for courage to be needed. Blood gathered under the lamplight, darker and thicker than I expected, embarrassingly mine. Ka-Syphiron turned my wrist so the drop hung from the thumb without falling. He pressed it to a polished stone plate marked with five faint circles. The drop flattened, found one shallow channel, and moved toward the northern mark. None of it entered the other four. The blood was warm; the stone was cold.

Blood enters service,
Sight enters discipline,
Pride enters correction.

Ka-Syphiron said. And I repeated.

"Rise now as Sa-Kailan, Candidate of Light."

The name fell on me like a door closing with me on one side of it.

— The prefixes, before you go on. *Sa* for a Candidate, *Va* for a Veil, *Ka* for a Keeper. Are there others I should have?

— Just the three.

The ceremony ran on. Tavan was named Sa-Tavan of Justice. The Hall did not cheer. The people struck two fingers against stone, once, twice, five times, and the sound filled the Hall like rain made hard. Va-Raedin leaned close enough that only I could hear.

"You answered poorly," he said.

My stomach dropped so cleanly that for a breath I forgot the blood. Then he added: "But not uninterestingly."

At the second sentence my shoulders loosened. I looked for Va-Sheva, wanting her to have heard it, but she was no longer watching the ceremony. Two wardens

had come close to her, one speaking without moving his head. Her expression tightened. One hand settled near her hilt; she glanced past the galleries and shifted her stance. Va-Raedin bound my thumb with a strip of pale cloth and pulled it tight.

"You will report to the northern practice hall before Second Silence," he said. "Do not eat heavily. Do not arrive proud."

"I am not proud," I said.

He tied the cloth too tightly. "You are fifteen. Pride is your natural condition."

I said nothing.

"Good," he said. "You have learned one thing already."

I waited with the others for Shield to open the Mountain and let us go down to supper. Shield did not open the Mountain. The wardens at the great gates set their backs to the stone and their faces to us. One of them placed his palm against the seam between the doors. Another lowered the crossbar into its sockets. The small sounds of a crowd beginning to rise — a knee gathering, a child lifted — stopped one by one, until the Hall was as still as it had been at the first chime.

Then the Keepers left us. They went one at a time, each into the low office arch beneath the proper pillar: Balance beneath Balance, Justice beneath Justice, Shield beneath Shield, and Ka-Syphiron down the northern stair of Light, past the plate where my blood had not yet dried. Last went Ka-Elun. She stopped at the Faith threshold and set her hand against the jamb. Va-Maera stepped forward with both hands raised and halted before touching the cowl. Our law allowed no living soul to follow a Keeper of Faith through that arch. Ka-Elun entered alone. The five arches closed. We were left in a Hall with no Keeper in it at all.

Where five Keepers had stood, five Veils remained. Va-Raedin waited beneath Light, a single pace from me, his hands folded. Va-Sheva stood beneath Shield, where the wardens had drawn her, the shorter blade loosened in its seat. Beneath Faith stood the second of Mereth's two Veils, Va-Maera, she who had not risen. Beneath Balance and Justice waited two more I knew only by the colour of their sashes.

Each Veil faced an office arch. Va-Maera's place lay nearest Faith. She kept one ear turned to its closed stone while her hands arranged the folds of her robe, flattened them, and arranged them again.

Va-Maera lifted the prayer, and the people answered. Her voice cracked on its first word. She swallowed, drew breath, and began again. We asked that the Beast keep to Hell and the Chains keep their count; that God remember the Covenant

and the price of being seen; that the hand set into Faith that morning had been set in rightly; that mercy be shown to those beneath the Mountain and, more quietly, to those beyond it. After each plea the Hall gave back seven words:

Let every breath be whole;
Let no one hand hold the whole.

"What did God give the hidden people?"
"Stone, water, and shadow." The response came from every Kahir.
"What did God take from the hidden people?"
"Sky, wandering, and the open world."
"What is kept beneath the Mountain?"
"The Temple."
"What is kept beneath the Temple?"

No one answered. In every rehearsal, that question had been followed by silence. A little girl two rows ahead opened her mouth, and her mother covered it before a sound escaped.

And it went on. The light in the two permitted shafts crossed the floor, reddened, and narrowed. The Pendulum swung above the forbidden circle, its turning line marking the hours. Its shadow passed the northern plate again and again, over the darkened print of my thumb. Oil burned down, and attendants of Light trimmed and refilled the lamps until the smell sat on the tongue. Children began to move, were hushed, and moved again. An old man near the Shield arch folded down without a sound, and Va-Sheva reached him before he struck the floor. I did not see her cross the space; she was simply there, one arm under him, lowering him the way you lower a full vessel you have resolved not to spill. She returned beneath her pillar with nothing shown on her face. My face heated. I had spent the day watching her hair.

I turned the name over without moving my lips: *Sa-Kailan*, *Sa-Kailan*. My cut thumb beat under Va-Raedin's linen. The wrapping had reddened where the blood came through. I waited for him to look at me; he did not. I found Va-Sheva across the Hall, looked down, and found her again. Once I lifted my head too far toward the closed arches. Va-Raedin's two fingers returned to my wrist and pressed my gaze to the stone. The prayer wore down into a continued murmur. A voice would fall out, then another, then return after water had passed along the rows. Va-Maera raised one hand. The sound stopped and did not begin again.

Into that silence the Mountain moved. The first stroke came straight up through the floor, into the knees and gut and back teeth, as though something the

size of the Hall had struck the underside of the world once with the flat of its hand. Dust left the carvings all at once, and the pillars smoked. A bowl rang. Somewhere glass broke. The Thread shivered; the great disk slipped sideways at the end of its crossing, hunted, and found its swing. Va-Raedin caught my shoulder before my hands reached the floor. A low single sound passed through the Hall.

Then nothing. Va-Maera held her hand aloft. Dust turned in the slanting light. A word went from beneath Justice; another returned from Balance; something passed along the five Veils in an order I could not follow. Nothing sounded at the closed arches. Va-Maera looked toward Faith. Va-Raedin turned his head toward the Light stair. Across the circle, Va-Sheva watched the Shield arch. The second stroke came after a long wait. This time the Hall did not cry out. It was the twin of the first, no larger, and it lifted the same loose edge of carpet beneath Faith. By the third I was counting. Three. The gap between the strokes was long and exact, the same to the breath each time. Va-Maera's head lifted a moment before each blow. Around me they prayed with their eyes shut. I counted with mine open. The fourth came. My body had learned the rhythm and leaned toward the next before it fell. I caught a word from beneath Faith, braced, and felt the heat of being seen though I caught no eye on me. After the floor settled, my injured thumb struck once inside its binding. The fifth fell no heavier than the others. I had expected it to grow. Its level force frightened me more.

Between the fourth and fifth, I counted breaths. I lost the count when someone sobbed, began again, and reached the same number with one breath to spare. Va-Raedin's fingers tightened before the stone rose.

Five. I had counted five. I waited for a sixth. The rows before me stayed still. Va-Maera bent her head toward the floor. The five arches stayed shut. The gates stayed shut. The prayer resumed, lower than before. The broken glass lay untouched.

The adults I could see watched the closed arches. Va-Sheva's hand had left her blade and rested flat against the Shield pillar. Va-Raedin kept two fingers on my shoulder. The Pendulum swung. Its line crept farther round its slow circle. The permitted light went from red to almost nothing. A child asked a question and was not answered. Water travelled along the rows in covered cups; mine had the taste of lamp smoke. We remained on our knees in the smell of spent oil and each other. After the fifth blow, the same measure began again without a stroke to mark its start.

At the point where my body expected a sixth blow, the answer came. The five had been sharp and near, each its own event, a fist beneath one floor. The swell made no sound I could hear. I felt a slow pressure in my teeth, in the water of the

eye, in the marrow of the leg against the stone. It rose through the floor and lifted my knees. Lamps shook. The pillars groaned. The hanging disk climbed on one long swell of the ground and settled. Bowls around the Hall sounded together, a soft chord of struck metal with no hand near them. Water in the two nearest offering basins rose without spilling and sank.

The swell passed, but its pressure remained in my teeth. The little girl two rows ahead had both hands clamped over her mouth. Her mother held her from behind, cheek against the child's hair, and kept looking toward Faith. Beneath Shield, Va-Sheva removed her palm from the pillar one finger at a time. Va-Raedin's hand had gone from my shoulder. I touched the cloth and found four clean streaks where his fingers had rested.

The Faith arch opened first, long after the swell had passed. Ka-Elun stepped through, one hand against the stone, the great cowl bowed by its own weight. Dust striped one shoulder. Va-Maera took half a step toward her. Ka-Elun raised two fingers, and the Veil stopped. The offering bowls had fallen silent.

"God answers."

Va-Maera lowered her raised hand. For one breath she and Ka-Elun faced each other across the place where the cowl had changed shoulders. Then Va-Maera bowed. Ka-Elun left the wall and crossed to the Faith pillar without assistance.

A long broken exhalation passed through the rows and broke into sobs near Faith. Stone moved at the other four arches. Balance and Justice passed behind their pillars before I saw them take their places. Shield crossed the open space opposite me. Ka-Syphiron returned last, closed the Light arch with his own hand, and looked once at the disk above us. I counted all five beneath their pillars. The Keeper of Shield turned toward the gates. Va-Maera gave the law once more. The people gave it back:

> *Let every breath be whole;*
> *Let no one hand hold the whole.*

Only then did Shield open the Mountain. The great gates drew back. Cool untasted air came from the deep passages and reached me as robes stirred along every tier. The Hall began to empty. Attendants pinched the lamp wicks one by one. On the southern wall the Genesis gravure darkened with them, until the carved Mountain lost its edges and the hidden Oasis went into shadow. I knelt among the rising people and looked into that shadow until my eyes began to invent shapes.

— Stop there. Before you leave that Hall, I think you have told me something you do not know you told me. The deep strokes, the hard ones from below: how many?

— Five. I counted them. Five.

— And the spacing between them: even, like a dripping tap? Or not?

— Even. Dead even. The same long wait to the breath each time, set by nothing I could see: no drum, no hand, no voice.

— Then the five stopped, and something different came after the next interval.

— After the same long wait. The five were blows, each its own, close under the floor. The answer was everywhere, slow and low, and lifted the whole Hall on one breath.

— How long between the last of the five and that answer? Set it against the gaps between the strokes.

— The same. One more of the long even measures, and then the Earth spoke. I cannot give it to you in minutes; I had no clock but the prayer. But it was even to the last.

— And the rite followed the raising of a Keeper. Every raising, or only that one?

— Every raising of a Keeper. It is very old. I was told it was the Mountain proving that the Chains still held after a hand upon them had changed.

— … Thank you. That is enough for now. I have your count and your interval. I want to set them down cleanly and ask Mrs Blackwood about a record she keeps. Sit. Take some water. I shall not be long.

Blackwood Estate — a monitoring room off the west corridor

In English

— You can leave the machine running; it is already on the house's record, as everything in this wing is. Sit down, Mr Morgan, before you fall down. You heard it too, then.

— Thank you, Mrs Blackwood. … I heard five deliberate sources and a return, and a people who would not call themselves safe until the return arrived.

— I know precisely what you heard. I have waited sixty-six years to be told. Five marks, even and exact, with one long interval between them and the same interval before what came behind: a broad slow swell across the whole instrument. I set it aside as noise, as the ground settling, as the desert being the desert. I have carried that trace in a drawer since I was twenty-seven years old, since an hour after Reggane in 1960.

— Jesus. … A readiness test, you think?

— That is my inference. Every time one of their hands changes, five sources and a return. The first four intervals give the source schedule. The fifth predicts the return.

— And the gates prove what the return means to them: they do not open them until it arrives.

— Then my working hypothesis is that the broad swell on your trace was a whole-Earth mode.

— And mine is that whatever they keep beneath that mountain may be coupled to the planet. … What in God's name do they have down there, that they test it through the Earth and teach the children to call the test a prayer?

— …

— No. Do not answer that; and I would not trust you if you tried. … Good work, Mr Morgan. Go back in. Keep him talking, and get me the rest: the trial, the exile, all of it, in his own time. Do not lead him, do not frighten him, do not tell him what he has just taught us. And Paul. He is not to know what I have just understood. Let him go on thinking me the woman who pays for the tea and nothing worse, and you a scholar paid to sift a young man's story. Gain his trust, Paul.

Chapter 2

Mirror

In English

— Package for you, Paul. Marmite; Fortnum tea; Fortnum biscuits. Did your mummy send them, or do they simply arrive for a man of your breeding? ... Ah. A Balvenie eighteen, cherry cask. So this is the work here, is it: whisky tasting? God. They pay you far too much. You are not slipping out this evening for a third week running: the chessboard is exactly where you bolted from it, it is my move, and I mean to have the game off you before we are both too old to lift a rook.

— Put it down, Urs, and go be impressed with yourself somewhere else. And you with the new haircut, trying to look like a true eighties golden boy? What comes next, the double-breasted jacket? Leave us in peace. Have you no supertankers stuck in the *strait* to go and play battleship with?

— Wait till you see the Pequignet. All right, see you later boys.

In Noxius

— Let us continue. Where were we?

The morning after they cut my hand, I came to the practice halls of Light before Second Silence with a sour empty stomach, a thumb bound in linen that tugged at the cut with every closing of the hand, and the private conviction that I would never, a second time, be made to look a fool.

> — Stop there. *First Light* I take for dawn; any man would. But *Second Silence*, you were sealed in stone, with no sky, no sun. How did you tell one hour from the next?
>
> — By the Pendulum. I have told you its size, and the length of the Thread; that it swings, back and forth, a little more than twenty of your seconds to cross and return. But the line of its swing also turns, slowly, across the floor. How would you name that?
>
> — Precession.
>
> — Just so. And it takes two and three-quarter days for that line to return to itself. Faith marks a ring on the floor around the Forbidden Circle; at each mark an attendant strikes a gong as the swing crosses it, so that a man who has seen no light all day knows whether it is First Light, Second Silence, Third Measure, Fourth Record, or Fifth Blade.
>
> — Five marks. Five gongs. Your day had five parts.
>
> — Five names, many marks. The names began again around the ring, almost three days of them laid down at once. Faith held the count and struck the proper gong. The marks never sat still. As the seasons drew the day long or short, Faith moved them a little, so the ring stayed honest against a sun we were forbidden to see. Measure was called our noon. Some days it was, most days near it, now and then an hour adrift. The sun settled it twice a year at the festival of Equal Light, when Third Measure was exactly noon.

The day before, those thresholds had admitted Kailan as a boy servant under instruction, suffered near the outer rooms because his teachers vouched for him. That morning the gate wanted a record of who I was. An attendant in a robe of dustless grey read my new name from a tablet whose characters had been incised so lately that a fine grit still lay unswept in the troughs of every stroke; and *Sa-Kailan*, in a stranger's mouth, sounded like a key turning in locks I had never been shown. The stone changed under my sandals as I crossed from common passage into Light. It became smoother, colder, so that a step both sounded and returned a faint image from below. Even the darkness was tended here, kept in its allotted places. A corridor beyond the gate was crossed by thin bars of light that fell from slits too high to see and vanished into black cuts on the far wall. I slowed despite myself. At Faith I had knelt; Balance had measured me; Shield had read my permission; Justice had entered me in its record. My first lessons in Light had been simpler: open your eyes; Light shows what is there.

The Hall of Light was several halls under one name, broad and shallow from one end, a blade of space from the stair, mirrors along one side and black apertures cut into the other. In a niche a Balance woman changed the salt-dishes that kept damp off the glass, weighing each wet one before setting down a dry. From the candidate entrance the place looked almost empty; a few steps in, mirrors stood everywhere, and none where a child would have set them — tall strips no wider than a hand, discs at knee or shoulder, some of dark polished stone that returned shape without obedience. They were made below, at the one great heat the Mountain allowed itself, from desert sand breathed over with a whisper of metal; and the Balance table beside that furnace marked every shovel of coal and left the last line of the seam's account blank. Arcs and crosses and incomplete circles had been cut into the floor. Three doorways stood at the far end. The left appeared open and dark, with light at its base; the middle was closed by metal; the right stood half-open, with a reflected line of brightness along its edge that I distrusted at once.

Va-Raedin of Light stood at the centre, hands folded behind his back, pale grey robe, no ornament but the narrow silver thread at the cuff. He looked rested. I resented it. The ceremony had lasted through the day, and he had stood through it without letting the hours show.

"You are early," he said.

"You said before Second Silence."

"I did." He looked at my bandage. "Does the thumb hurt?"

"No."

"It should."

"It does a little."

"Then start with the truth when truth is inexpensive."

Heat moved into my face, and I said nothing. He turned to the three doors.

"Which door opens?"

I nearly answered quickly, and disliked myself for the impulse. The right doorway's brightness was so plainly a lure that the lure might be to distrust it too easily. I studied the floor instead.

"The left," I said. "The light at its base belongs to an opening. The right only reflects one. The middle is meant to make the eye feel opposed."

"Open it."

I crossed the hall to the left-hand facade and pushed. Nothing. Pulled. Nothing. I searched for latch, seam, hinge, weight. My hands found only smooth stone, and behind me Va-Raedin stayed quiet, which I hated more than correction.

"You asked which door opens," I said. "Not which door appears open."

"No."

I looked again. Doors, mirrors, floor. The nearest cut circle was worn on one side only, as though candidates had learned to step into it from the same direction. So I stood inside it, and the room changed. The mirrors no longer held the three doors. They caught a plain stone panel behind me, flush with the wall, unmarked by light. I found the seam by touch and pressed, and it opened inward. I pressed my mouth flat. His eyes moved to it.

"Light deceives," I said.

"No. That is the small thing, and the proud one." He did not move. "From the door you chose well among the three the room offered you. From the circle you saw the room that had laid the three out to be chosen among. A Candidate who follows brightness serves whoever placed the lamp."

"A Veil learns who placed the lamp," I said.

"Eventually. When he stops being proud of finding a door built to be found, and asks what wanted it found."

I went into the dark chamber before I could be told.

The second room was narrower and colder, lit through slits so thin they should have lit nothing. On a stone table lay a mirror shard, a black measuring rod, a bead of clear glass fixed to a white tile, a bowl of water, and two bronze wedges. Va-Raedin closed the hidden door, and the darkness thickened, then organised itself around the slits.

"Move the point of light onto the far wall."

"May I touch the lamp?"

"No. But you may touch what is on the table."

I began with the shard. The nearest slit sent a fine blade of light too high to catch, and I angled the shard until the light jumped downward, crossed the black rod, and vanished. For minutes I worked at an exercise easy to understand and forever slipping from my hands. Each time the point steadied, the smallest movement of my wrist sent it running. My bandaged thumb made the shard hard to grip; I compensated with the wrong fingers, overcorrected, lost the beam, found it, and heard Va-Raedin breathe once through his nose. At last I set the mirror flat and used the water, tipping the bowl until its surface caught the beam and threw it upward, unstable but bright; the point moved with every tremor in the bowl. I held my breath until the surface stilled.

"Acceptable," Va-Raedin said.

"The water answers after the hand has left it," I said.

"Better." He watched the point tremble on the wall. "The disturbance is one thing; the trace it leaves is another. The water tells you a disturbance occurred. It does not always tell you what or who disturbed it. Young minds love to turn traces into stories."

By the time he led me on it was past Third Measure, and the passages carried the grind of carts and the iron report of a gate tested by Shield. In one chamber he crossed to a blackened panel, laid his hand flat upon it and asked where the exit was. The entrance behind us was one answer, and so probably wrong; his hand drew my eye to the panel, too large, too flat, no seam unless soot hid it. I walked toward it. He removed his hand, and I found no seam at all, and stopped.

"Why did you come here?"

"You drew attention to it."

"Yes. And?"

I looked back. Standing at the panel, his body had blocked a low mirror behind him; with him gone the reflection crossed the room and struck the left arch, showing that the floor beyond it stopped.

"You hid the falsehood by standing in front of the light," I said.

"That is what a Keeper of Light does. I am a Veil. I prevented you from seeing the condition that gave the falsehood shape. A lamp in the wrong place blinds more thoroughly than darkness."

"The distinctions are convenient," I said.

"They are. That does not make them false."

The chamber that followed was lit by a single lamp on the floor, ringed by six mirrors on slender metal stems, each facing the lamp at a different angle.

"Place them so the lamp finds the door," he said.

I wasted minutes on the brightest patch, a reflection of a reflection. I traced it from lamp to mirror, mirror to wall, wall to nothing. "There is no door for the lamp to find," I said. Va-Raedin smiled but did not correct me. I stopped searching the wall and crouched. From the floor I saw that one mirror reflected the gap between two brighter paths. I shifted it toward the gap. A pale line sharpened on the wall; another mirror sent it downward; a seam appeared at ankle height. A panel. By the time the panel opened, my knees ached and the linen on my thumb had darkened with new blood. Inside lay a small metal token, heavier and finer

than anything a boy is usually given to keep. It was a broad disk at the centre, pierced by a hole no wider than a hair, and round the disk ring upon ring, close-set and perfectly even, spreading to the rim like the rings a dropped stone leaves in a still bowl.

"Take it," he said. "Proof that you opened the room. Keep it, and do not show it; it is not easily made, and I will not cut you another."

I turned it once between finger and thumb, made nothing of the rings, and put it away.

— Forgive the intrusion; do not get up, either of you. I wanted only to see my two clevernesses with my own eyes. Are we making progress?

— Mrs Blackwood, we are. Slowly, and well.

— Slowly and well will do very nicely. I shall leave you to it; I am late for a call I have already kept waiting twice. Leave them be, both of you; they are working.

[—]

— ... And that was? She speaks my tongue very well.

— That was the woman who pays for the tea. Sarah.

— The tall red-faced one I can place: your Urs, the one who likes to tease you. The old one I cannot. He watched your machine more than he watched us, did you notice?

— That is only Martinez. He goes where she goes. His father worked for Edward, Sarah's father; the son stayed on for her.

— He goes where she goes, you say. ... And stands where the light is behind him. Like a shadow.

— The token, then. Go back to it for me. What was cut into it, exactly?

— A disk at the centre, a tiny hole in the middle. Around the disk, rings: many, close-set, even, spreading out to the rim. Like the rings a stone leaves on a still pool, but held in the odd pale colour and never moving.

— A token of light, cut to look like ripples of water. ... Stay there a moment. This will not take long.

[—]

— Forgive me; that took longer than I said. I have had a thing fetched up and printed here, on this sheet. Never mind what it is, or where I got it. Only this: did the token look like that?

— Yes. Exactly like that. Except yours is red, and mine was pale upon pale. ... How would you know?

— ...

> — Paul. I have been asked that question once already today, by a better man than either of us, and I gave the wrong answer to it. Who placed this sheet in front of me?
>
> — ... Well. All right. All right. And when he set the token in your hand, did you know what it was? What it meant?
>
> — Not then. But I would come to learn it, later.

A passage overlooked a lower work hall through narrow slits. Below, Faith singers rehearsed near a side arch, and no song reached me through the stone, only a low pressure in the rail beneath my hand, as if the wall had taken the note and returned its body without its words. A thin mist rose behind the singers and turned pale at the exact moment they lifted their faces.

Va-Raedin let me look. After a while he asked: "What do you see?"

"Water in the air. Light placed to make it visible. Timing."

"Do not admire the flame," he said. "Ask where the air enters." And I looked again, past the pale glow, to the fine line of holes above the arch that fed the mist, so fine they might have been pores in the rock, and to the hidden lamp placed to turn the vapour pale.

Below, a singer raised both hands, and the mist thickened with the movement as though the prayer had called it. The stone under my palm answered a breath after the bodies below. He nodded once.

"Do they know?" I asked.

"Know what?"

"The holes. The lamp."

"They know the prayer."

"That is not an answer."

"No."

"If God provides through valves, do the valves disprove Him, or serve Him?"

"You have been in Light one day. Leave Faith its quarrel."

The mist thinned. The stone released its low answering hum.

It was almost Fourth Record, and the work had worn my attention to a thin wire, when Va-Raedin stopped me between two dark chambers, asked a question for which I had no answer, and waited.

"You have said a sentence since before you could reason," he said. "*A Candidate learns where light falls.* Say it to me. Then tell me what it means."

I said it, and then said what it meant: that a Candidate learns the Mountain's light as a mason learns its stone, every shaft and slit and aperture, so that Light

might be kept and mended and never fail the halls that leaned upon it. I was rather pleased with the answer.

"That," Va-Raedin said when I had finished, "is what a mirror would tell you, if you could teach a mirror to speak."

He took one of the plain strips of glass from a niche in the passage, a hand's width, no more, and held it up between us, angled so that I saw my own face in it, badly, lit from beneath.

"What does this do?"

"It returns what falls on it," I said.

"Exactly. It returns what falls on it, adds nothing, keeps nothing. Perfectly faithful and perfectly empty. Three-and-twenty thousand festivals of equal light this Mountain has counted, and turned its mirrors to the sun at every one, and no mirror is the wiser for a single festival."

He turned the glass until his face displaced my own. "You have described the work of a mirror. I asked for the work of a Candidate. Which will you be? A mirror, or an eye?"

He did not wait on the answer. "A thing that has met three-and-twenty thousand festivals and is standing yet — what does it tell you?"

"That it is likely to meet three-and-twenty thousand more."

"Perhaps. Now ask what it removed, each festival, to keep the next the same."

> — Festivals of equal light, twenty-three thousand of them. That is eleven and a half thousand years.
>
> — Va-Raedin told me there was a clock, in a room I was never brought to. It was nothing like yours; it kept no hours, and no mornings. It beat once only, at each festival of equal light: twice in the year, never between. What cogs and weights turned inside it to keep it so patient, I was not privy to. I was never Light enough to be shown.

He returned the plain strip to the niche from which he had taken it.

"Come," he said. "I will show you where light falls."

He took me down by a stair I had never been shown, below the practice halls, to an unbarred door with no warden before it. On the stair he told me that Light brought only its three ranks to the threshold, and required silence from each until the next had stood there. The room beyond was long and low and nearly dark, cold as places the day never enters. The wall to the left we entered by was pierced

from floor to ceiling with small round holes, hundreds of them, each no wider than a fingertip, and through every one came a single thread of light, so that the wall to my right was a field of faint stars shining the wrong way — inward, out of the body of the Mountain.

The wall to my right puzzled me at first. It carried points of light too, where the threads crossed the dark and stopped; but they obeyed no rank, no order. They were scattered across the black face of the stone — some in clusters, some alone, some steady and bright, some so faint I found them only by looking beside them. It might have been a night sky copied by a hand that refused constellations.

Then Va-Raedin raised a shielded lamp to the wall's lower edge, and I saw faint lines scored between the points, joining them into shapes. The skin of my arms tightened. I knew the shapes. I had walked them that same morning. The long gallery of Light. The stair we had just come down. The washing pools, in their two uneven rows. The food galleries. And there, low and to one side, the great round of the Hall of Ceremony and its ring of five pillars.

"We call it the Mirror," Va-Raedin said. "Every beam in the Mountain ends here: here is nothing but the ends of beams. The wall precedes the Mountain. Now the Mountain follows the wall. Watch."

We stood a while and the points held still, most of them, most of the time; then near the middle of the wall, at a passage between the food galleries and the lower cells, a single point stirred: dimmed, steadied, dimmed again, and went still.

"Someone crossed the light there," Va-Raedin said. "The beam does not care who. It tells you where and when a body passed between source and wall. Not the face. Not the burden. It need not watch you always. Leave a man unable to tell its sleeping hours from its waking ones, and he will keep the rest himself."

Between First Light and Fifth Blade, he told me, the halls move and the wall flickers like water in wind. After Fifth Blade the Mountain holds still by its long law, and a single stirring point is as loud upon the Mirror as a shout in an empty hall.

"You will learn each point," Va-Raedin said. "Which beam it is, and which place it stands for, and what its stirring means, and what its stillness means, which is harder. There are two hundred and fifty-six of them on this wall. No two candidates learn them in the same order, and there is no shorter road. A Candidate learns where light falls. Light falls here."

I stood before the wall that could find any body in the Mountain and thought it the most beautiful thing I had ever laid eyes upon. I told him nothing. Around us, two hundred and fifty-six points held their places.

— It is a good place to leave the morning. The afternoon and tomorrow run as agreed: a few hours with the tutor, and then the physician asks an hour of you for the body. He is not content with your numbers.

— Instruction, yes; I will sit with your tutor. The physician and his hour, we shall see. Do you know what they will teach me?

— The shape of it, yes. The exact content or the methodology, no. We are kept apart; the House calls it compartmentalisation. Each account is to be taken clean, free of the others' influence. Come. I will show you where you will eat.

Blackwood Estate — Drawing room, past midnight

In Noxius

— You are up. … Wait: say that again, I want it on the reel. … Forgive the machine at this hour. I gave my word the first morning that nothing we said would go unkept, and I would sooner keep it badly than keep it only by daylight.

— It is the light. The one the tutor set on the wall this afternoon. I shut my eyes and it is still burning. … And this house keeps a lamp lit in every room the night long, for no one at all. Anyway. … I was thinking of the sea. Is it far from here?

In English

— One second, Urs. There. … Knight d three. The octopus.

In Noxius

— Never mind the game, and never mind Urs. One of his boats is lost, fast in a strait; he is awaiting news from his contact in Isfahan, and none have come.

— You see, it is so large that a man may lose a whole boat inside it. … Is it far from here?

— Quite far. … Let me see if I can find you something here, with pictures in it.

[—]

In English

— Paul. The coffee table. … Under the Elizabeth Kolbert.

— Ah: excellent idea.

In Noxius

— Here. *The World, From Above*. Now off you go.

Chapter 3

Oasis

— The nineteenth of March, nine o'clock; the second of our interviews. Before we begin, if you wish to ask any question about instruction these past two days, now is the time. Yesterday was *Life On Earth*, I am told: the whole ladder of it, from the first speck to your own hand. This afternoon they turn to the heavens.

— I wish. It began with time. A man took me down into a great red canyon, wall standing over wall, and taught that each layer beneath was older than the one above it; and that the floor of it was older than the whole of my scripture. He said something I wrote down:

> *These immense periods of time baffle the imagination.*

You do not say. My people count the years of the world in their thousands and think themselves ancient. He counts them in their millions, and had the rock to prove it. I did not know a rock could be young or old. And in those rocks there were beasts, Paul: creatures caught in the stone where they had died an age ago, held in the rock as a fly is held in sap. It sent me back, this morning, to a thing I had passed twice and thought nothing of: on the wall of the passage you bring me down, a beast with five teeth and a crown upon it, set there as though by a furious child. After those creatures in the stone, I stopped before it a long while. What is it? In the Mountain, a thing like that would be a warning, or a god.

— Ha. That. A painting by a man called *Basquiat*, dead very young, and worth a good deal more than the house it hangs in. We pay a king's ransom to frame the fury a child would be corrected for, then hang it where every guest must pass.

— I should like to hold the instrument in my own hands, the microscope, and see this DNA he spoke of with my own eyes, and not take it on a voice's word.

— We have one downstairs for looking at cells; its lenses cannot resolve the double helix. Whether you are granted it is not mine to say, nor the tutor's; that door opens higher up than either of us. I will ask.

— There it is again: the wall you will not walk past. Every house I have been kept in has had one. But sleep went from me over something else. Your kind is permitted to ask; that is what I lay listening to. Where I was raised, scripture is the answer to a question, not the start of one. That voice spoke in questions and partial answers, and called the rest a mystery still to be pierced.

And the moving picture: I have thought of little else. It is light, Paul, placed and turned by a hand I was not shown. We would have named it the most dangerous object ever made and given it to Shield to bury. Yet I sat before it and could not look away. Nor could I stop asking the two questions my whole life trained into me: who chose what I was shown, and what did they leave in the dark? I assumed you were watching me watch it. I was raised under the finest eyes my world ever made, and I can feel a trained watcher through a wall. So tell me: who stood behind the glass?

— No one. That I know of. I was not there; I spend those hours replaying the tape and taking notes. The tutor sat with you. But about the lamp, you are not wrong. We have used it to persuade whole nations to love a war before a reason was given, or to want a thing they had no want of an hour before. This house, and much of my world with it, runs on the lamp.

— … A room with no eye in it, and a man who grants the point when he might have kept his silence. That is the most honest thing you have said to me. Then answer one thing while the honesty lasts. If your house trusts the lamp to show me the history of life, why will it not trust me with the instrument by which I might test it?

— Because the tutor may show you, the physician may mend you, and neither holds every key in the house. Which brings me to my smaller errand. You kept your hours with the tutor yesterday, then sent the physician away. The exercise. You would not do it.

— Paul. I mean you no disrespect; you have been courteous, and courtesy is not nothing. But understand what you are asking, and of whom. I sat among the ten who mattered most in a world eleven thousand years old. Men knelt when I passed them. Lives were kept, or were not, upon my word. And you would set me in coloured cloth to chase a ball across a lawn while grown men clap and call it improvement. I did not come this far, through all that has been taken from me, to be entertained by silly games.

> — It is a game, and it is not. It is complicated. The body is an instrument, and yours has come to us badly out of tune. The physician would begin again with swimming; there is a private pool beneath the east wing. He reads numbers, not men. I thought it might suit a man who has had his fill of being watched.
>
> — No. ... No: yes. I will do the swimming. The man whose voice it was yesterday did more than cross the top of the water; he went down beneath it, in a red tunic, with a large yellow bottle behind his back, and moved among the creatures there as though he belonged with them. You have a pond in your garden; I have watched it all morning from the window. Train me to swim, then to dive, and give me the glass. I can go down into that pond and learn for myself whether the man on the light told me the truth or only a good story.
>
> — That is more than the physician had in mind; but I will try for it. Now: yesterday you left me at the Mirror, the wall where all of it falls. What did Light do with you the next morning?
>
> — It gave me a beam of my own to learn. Before I could trace it that morning, I was granted permission to go outside, for the second time in my life, and the beam remained to be walked.

My mother said the first had been at my blessing and that the Mountain had folded the sky away before I could remember it. The permission came to me on a strip of pale bark, folded twice and sealed with green wax. The seal was Balance green: the cup and the sealed jar pressed deep into the wax, crossed by a narrow black witness line and the small hard stamp of Shield. I broke it with my thumb. The old cut pulled under the bandage.

> *Sa-Kailan, Candidate of Light, is granted one controlled prayer access before the Oasis at the Third Measure. Duration: one silence before and one silence after the water prayer. Route: east lower passage, cedar gate, second threshold, shaded descent. Measured by Balance. Witnessed by Justice. Held by Shield.*

I tied the bandage on my thumb, untied it, and tied it again so the linen sat cleanly over the cut. My mother watched from the wall recess where she had been folding cloth.

"You will keep your eyes lowered through the water prayer."

"I know."

"You will not ask Shield why a path is closed."

"I know."

My father looked up from the tablet he had been marking. "Outside is not a reward."

"Yes it is."

"It is not a private revelation."

"Unless you have the devotion and the eye to see what is revealed."

"It is a place where the Mountain becomes harder to protect."

"A boy with his eyes open was never the danger."

I left before he could answer.

The familiar passages to the cedar gate felt strange that morning, because I was walking them in order, outward. Checkpoint, gate, count, threshold, descent: each had stood there yesterday and I had walked past it blind. Today I passed through each one wondering what it was for. A Justice clerk read the green wax against a slate — time mark, name, bandaged thumb — and pressed a clay counter into my palm.

"Return this at the second threshold. If you lose it, the route remains open in the record, and Shield searches until it is closed."

"I will not lose it."

"That is the usual intention."

It was small and rough and stamped with a number. I put it in the inner fold of my robe, apart from the Light token. At the cedar gate two attendants stood beside a shallow basin, washing every leaving body into the proper condition and giving water enough for rite and no more. There were seven of us: myself; three older women from the western family chambers, one in a grey shawl; a boy with a single cloudy eye, led by one of them; and two workers with grey mourning cords at their wrists. The water the Faith attendant poured over my hands was colder than I expected.

"Speak only what is appointed before the Oasis. Take nothing from the ground."

"I will not."

The boy with the cloudy eye began to cry when the water touched his mouth. His aunt bent close and whispered to him. The two men with mourning cords said nothing at all.

Beyond the cedar gate waited Shield: black iron bands behind the wood, a locking bar thick enough to stop a cart, two wardens before it and a third in a side niche whose black leather showed between two folds of hanging cloth. The senior warden read our marks one by one.

"Prayer access. The Measure. Seven bodies out. Seven bodies due." He looked at me last. "Candidate of Light."

"Yes."

"Eyes where Faith places them. Feet where Balance marks them. If Shield speaks, you obey before understanding."

"I understand."

"No," the warden said. "You agree. Understanding is not required."

The iron bar was lifted by two hands and a lever set into the wall. A narrow bell sounded somewhere beyond the gate; another sounded farther down the stone. The descent beyond the cedar gate was cut between natural rock and worked stone. At first it felt like any lower passage: dim, damp, controlled, with lamps set in protective recesses and the smell of water in the cracks. Then the lamps stopped. Light lay on the floor in a pale wedge. It came from somewhere ahead, full of dust and height, careless in its angle, making each stair deeper and then shallower as I moved.

"Eyes down until the mark," the Shield warden said.

I lowered my gaze to the steps. The outside light was brighter, and undisciplined, and it took some minutes for my eyes to adapt. At the last turn, the Mountain opened. The sky struck me first as sheer height, and after that as blue. The Mountain had ceilings; even its highest halls ended somewhere, and had taught my eye to expect an end. I kept my eyes low, and failed, and above the dark shoulder of the Mountain the open brightness went on and on, with no vault to end it and no hand to have placed it. Faith led us to the marked prayer stones. There we were permitted to look. The Oasis lay under the Mountain's shadow. Green crowded the water and climbed the dark stone. My throat closed. For one breath I forgot the prayer.

The Genesis gravure had shown me a spring inside a ring of trees, and I had knelt to that carving my whole life. I had come out to hold the carving against the thing itself, as I meant one day to hold a pond against a voice on a lit glass. Before me, bees worried the warm rock. Water travelled under leaves and vanished into cuts too narrow for a finger. Small white flowers had rooted themselves in the cracks of the slope, and wherever the shade shifted, something living leaned after it. Along the Mountain's foot, where the night's chill still slept in the stone, the hardiest plants wore a fur of dew. I watched one bead gather on a leaf, swell, and fall inward into a seam before the sun could take it. The hill drank through its own wall.

A woman trimmed a reed and passed the cuttings to a child carrying feed. Beneath the palms, fish broke the green surface where scraps had been thrown. Smoke drifted from the hives; a child sprinkled water over the snail trays; another woman scraped fibre from soaked stalks and laid it to dry beside sheets of new paper. Where the drying channel pans had gone white, a Balance worker scraped the salt up before the water reached the beds and carried it toward the preserving tables. A boy swept fallen grain from a threshing cloth into a basket and took the chaff toward the goat pens.

> — How large was it, in the shadow of the Mountain?
>
> — Enormous, I do not know how to count it.
>
> — The silly games pitch. Bigger or smaller?
>
> — Hard to say: it was circular and irregular. Five, six, maybe ten of those.
>
> — Circular. How many steps from one end to the opposite end, going through the middle.
>
> — Eight hundred, or maybe a thousand.

Beyond it the desert expanded, and outside the Mountain's shadow the light bleached detail from the sand. The Mountain held the hollow in shade from the north; to the south a second height stood out of the sand, a third its size and set so close that the Oasis lay caught between the two like a seed between a thumb and a finger. What those two left open, a farther ridge to the south-east all but closed, and to the south-west dune lay across dune, so that a man would have had to stand at one precise and distant place to see even the tops of the trees. The green ran on past the point the prayer-party was let to see: terrace above terrace along the Mountain's cooler flank, palms, then lower trees, then crops in their shade, more than the holy hollow held — and a man out on the sand would swear the whole hill was barren stone. To reach the high terraces the water had to be sent back uphill, and that took a machine: a wheel of clay pots on a shaft that two goats walked in a slow circle, each pot filling low and spilling high.

The old women knelt. I knelt with them. The Faith attendant unrolled a strip of pale bark and held it with both hands before the water. She named the reading: the second book of the Covenant, the *Book of Blood*.

And after the fifth day, God spoke unto Adam and unto Eve,

— Adam and Eve?

— Paul, please do not interrupt me when I recite scripture. God would not approve.

— Of course. My apologies.

And after the fifth day, God spoke unto Adam and unto Eve, and unto the five children whom He had set in the Oasis beneath the shadow of the Mountain; and God said, Let there be Keepers among you, that the Mountain be not without order, nor the Oasis without care, nor the people without peace. And God called the woman of water, and said unto her, Keep thou the Balance, and gather the fruits, and count the waters; keep the seed for sowing and the grain for eating, and let neither be spent for the other. And God called the woman of holy speech, and said unto her, Keep thou the Faith, and teach My Gospel unto the children; keep the words in their mouths, and the names of their fathers, that the old be remembered when their voices cease.

The Balance workers moved in the distance as the words were spoken. One woman checked the level in a narrow cut along the main channel. On the high terraces the barley stood pale, and a line of women worked along it with short hooks. A clerk marked a hanging board and moved a shell counter from one hook to another.

And God called the man of strength, and said unto him, Keep thou the Shield, and stand before the beasts of the Earth, and before the Threshold of men; suffer not the children to be devoured, nor danger to enter unnamed. And God called the woman of brightness, and said unto her, Keep thou the Light, and illuminate the Mountain, and teach the eye where to stand, that the people stumble not in darkness. And God called the man of peace, and said unto him, Keep thou Justice, and stand between brother and brother, and keep the record of sequence, that blood answer not blood without measure. And the Keepers received their charges, and each kept what had been given.

And the people brought the fruits of their labour unto the Oasis, and the Keepers set portions before them. And God said, Leave bread for him who keepeth watch, and carry water unto her who cannot rise to drink. Let the old teach the children

while the strong go forth to labour, and let food be set before them together. And the children learned the names of the trees from those who rested in their shade.

And the Keepers had sons and daughters, and their children had children after them; and the Oasis was filled with voices, and the Mountain gave shadow, and the waters were counted, and the Gospel was taught, and the beasts were driven back, and the lamps were lit, and peace was kept among the people. And the Keeper of Shield had two sons; and the elder was great in strength, and broad in the shoulder, and mighty before the beasts; and the younger was small in his body, and cunning in his heart. And the younger looked upon his brother, and saw that the people loved his strength, and envy entered him as a serpent entereth the grass.

And the younger spoke softly unto his brother, and smiled with his mouth while murder grew within him; and he rose against his brother in secret, and slew him where no beast had entered. And the first blood of man cried from the dust. And fear came upon the people, for Shield had defended the Oasis from the beasts without, but had not seen the beast within. And the younger fled from the Oasis, and took with him the wife of his brother, a daughter of Faith, and went out from the shadow of the Mountain into the open land.

I looked toward Shield before I meant to. The perimeter wardens held their places. Each faced the desert while the scripture named the murder behind Shield's back.

And God saw that blood had entered the world of men, and that holy speech had been carried out of the Mountain in the hands of the stolen daughter of Faith; and God cursed them, saying, Thou shalt wander under the eye of Heaven, and the Earth shall not hide thee. Thy children shall thirst for what they cannot keep, and conquer what they cannot love. Thou shalt remember the Mountain, but thou shalt not find it; and thou shalt hear the Gospel, but twist it into hunger. And from the murderer and the stolen daughter came the Outsiders.

— There. It is finished, and you may have your question now: the one you have held since Adam and Eve.

— You have those two names. A garden; a first man; a first woman; a brother who kills his brother in a field. We have that book, or one very near it. I did not think to meet it coming the other way, out of a mountain the world has never heard of.

> *— And the Outsiders multiplied in the open land, and their kings became many, and their cruelty became without number; and they remembered the Mountain in dreams, and hated the shade they could not find. And they gathered armies, and forged blades, and raised engines of war, and came with banners and drums and false prayers upon their tongues.*

False prayers upon their tongues, Paul.

— In our gospel, God forbids Eve from eating the fruit from the tree of knowledge. She does, and God is angry.

— Are women not allowed instruction in your world?

— They are, and they are not. It is complicated.

— Women keep our sacred words. Men kneel when they speak. I think ours are freer than yours. Who wrote your gospel?

— Priests, some twenty-five to forty centuries back, out of older stories still; and it is argued to this day. But the book does not divide us. The woman does. In mine she crosses the threshold by her own hand, and is blamed for it still. In yours she never crosses at all: she is carried over, taken as plunder, blameless because she never lifts a hand. We are two peoples telling one quarrel, each from his own end of it. Mine follows your murderer out of the shade, and the woman he took with him.

— You are wondering whether I know to whom I am speaking. I know exactly, Paul. You are of the open land. By the book I have set before you, you are the murderer's child. You remembered the Mountain. And, against the curse, you found it. I am the sitting proof.

— That is a large accusation to lay on a man across his own fire. The tutor sets you before the first cell and the long climb up to your own hand, and you kneel in the sand and hand me a garden, a murder, and a cursed line walking out into the country I was born in. I am a man of science, and I will not argue a man's scripture while he recites it from memory. Let us continue.

The attendant lowered the bark. For a while no one moved, and the bees went on working the warm rock.

I was allowed to stand after the first silence, and to step to the third marker, and look. Then I saw Va-Sheva of Shield. She stood near the southern perimeter beyond the herb beds, where the Oasis began to turn back toward bare rock. She wore dark Shield leather over her robe, a cloth wrapped round her throat, curls of hair gathered on her left shoulder. She was looking away from me, toward the outer path. As she turned, the sun showed the dark green of her eyes and broke into small moving fires along her hair. I thought, God forgive me, of the archangels I had heard named all my life and never seen: beings of pure light, loosed and dancing on a shield warden's hair.

One of the wardens spoke to her. She kept her eyes on the path and lifted two fingers; one man moved toward the goat pens and another took the outer stones. Then she saw me. One corner of her mouth moved and stopped. She crossed toward me while the Faith attendant went to help the old women. I became suddenly aware of my robe, my bandaged thumb, the sand on my sandals, and the fact that I had been looking too long at everything.

"*Kay* — I mean Sa-Kailan," she said. The prefix in her voice stung, and I was glad of it anyway.

"Va-Sheva." Her eyes went to my thumb. "Light has already started cutting pieces off you."

"Only the useless ones."

"That cannot be true. You are still standing."

I almost laughed. Her mouth moved too.

"You were at the Hall," I said, because I had to say something and chose badly.

"So were most of the people."

Wind moved between us, smelling of goat and wet stone, and under it something dry from beyond the shade.

"You have grown," she said. The words should have pleased me.

"So have you," I said, then hated myself. This time she smiled.

"I had four years' advantage."

"Five, almost."

"You counted?"

"Everyone knows."

My eyes came back from the channels and went where they had no leave to go, and her gaze followed mine and caught me there.

"No," she said. "Boys know such things when they should be learning where to put their eyes." I felt myself stay fifteen in front of her, out of reach completely and intolerably. Even so, her eyes kept returning to the perimeter.

"You are on duty."

"Yes."

"Then should you be speaking to me?"

"No. But I am," she said.

The blood came up into my face, and a smile got away from me. Years before, behind the cistern, she had stolen lamp-oil with me and blamed the smell on a kitchen cat. Then her gaze returned to the perimeter. For a moment we stood side by side and said nothing, both looking outward. I wanted to ask whether she had ever gone past the second ridge, whether Shield feared the Outsiders as scripture feared them or as wardens feared tracks in dust.

"The reading said the Outsiders came from the murderer. Do you believe it?"

"I believe the Mountain is hidden for a reason."

"That is not an answer."

"Do you believe the Book of the Beast?"

"You mean," I said carefully, "that the five Keepers hold together the Beast of Hell, in case the Outsiders come back."

"That is what children say."

"It is what Faith teaches children."

"Faith teaches children the shape of things. Not the weight."

"And what do you say?" I asked her. "Not Faith, not Ka-Dhavar of Shield. You."

"You have worn your prefix for three days and already want the Beast weighed for you."

"Then tell me only whether it is real."

She was silent long enough that I gave up on an answer.

"Shield does not post wardens at empty gates," she finally said.

"The Oasis is so much bigger than the gravures made it," I said after a while.

"The desert is larger."

I looked toward it. The outer path ran out toward the south-east, where a farther ridge stood against the deep desert. On that ridge, for less than a breath, something caught the sun and threw it back, then went dark. I narrowed my eyes.

"What was that?"

Va-Sheva's gaze moved instantly. "Where?"

"There. On the second ridge, the dark stone."

"Do not point." My hand had begun to lift. I lowered it.

"What was it?"

And God called the desert the Threshold;
and He set heat upon it by day,
and cold upon it by night,
and mirage upon its face,
that no man should cross it lightly.

I believed none of it.

Va-Sheva made three gestures in succession: two fingers low, the palm closed, the hand cut toward the outer path. One warden went behind the goat pens and disappeared in shade; another knelt in the dust at the outer marker; a figure answered from the rock above the descent, where I had seen only stone. The Faith attendant pressed her lips together. One of the old women tried to rise and her companion drew her down. A goat stopped chewing. Va-Sheva crouched beside the kneeling warden, touched the ground, rubbed something between her fingers and looked from the outer path to the ridge where I had seen the light. The warden near the stones gave a low call.

"Marker."

One outer marker had been turned. Barely. A flat side faced inward where the others faced skyward. Va-Sheva kept her hands off it, read the dust around it and the path beyond, and then spoke aloud.

"No one returns inside yet."

The Faith attendant's eyes widened. "The access period—"

"Has changed."

"By whose order?"

"Shield holds the Threshold," Va-Sheva said. The attendant lowered her head.

"Good."

A young Balance boy near the herb beds began to cry and covered his mouth with both hands. Va-Sheva walked the marker line without stepping beyond it. At the turned stone she knelt, took a thin bone pin from her sleeve, and lifted a single strand from the ground; it caught the light once, pale against her glove, before she sealed it in a covered dish. "Second gate," she said, and a watcher answered from the slope. Then she turned to the workers.

"Count."

Balance called every tool to its tally, every beast to its pen, every worker to a name. By the tally I heard, nothing was missing from the work.

"Prayer group?"

The Faith attendant named seven. The warden corrected her.

"Six."

The attendant froze. Then one of the old women said sharply, "Mara." The woman beside her looked round. "She has gone out to the south-west markers."

An hour before, I had heard it read over their heads that the beast had come from inside the house, and had watched every warden face the sand while it was said. The one we were missing had knelt beside me through the reading.

Va-Sheva crossed the prayer area at a fast walk, two wardens spreading behind her. The Faith attendant whispered, "God keep her in shadow." Va-Sheva heard. "Silence." The prayer stopped.

From the third prayer stone I could see past the south-west channel to the open markers. They found Mara crouched against a dry stone, one hand flat on it, breathing hard and unable to rise, a sprig of dried herb from the beds still in the other. A Balance worker beside me made a sound low in her throat. Va-Sheva took the sprig, passed it to a warden, helped Mara stand and spoke close to her ear until she closed her eyes and nodded. A warden lifted the grey shawl from her shoulders, folded the dusty hem inward and carried it apart from her.

Then she signalled. The turned marker remained under guard. The second ridge threw back no more light. The old woman was returned to Faith, who received her with a face drained of colour. Va-Sheva came back to the inner shade. Her eyes passed over the group, counted, and settled briefly on me. "Seven bodies held," she said. "Eleven Balance workers held."

The Faith attendant said very quietly, "She is old."

"Yes."

"She meant no harm."

"Intent does not close a breach."

Mara began to weep silently. I looked away. The channel was checked. A small clay seal was pressed beside her name. The prayer group was recounted. The Balance workers lifted their tools without speaking and returned to their tasks.

"You saw the flash first."

"I think so."

"You did not point when told not to."

"No."

"Good."

"Were the three of them connected?" I asked.

"The flash, the marker, and the old woman out of place? Probably not."

"Then why—" She looked at me, and I stopped.

"Because at the Threshold, we join them first and separate them later."

The Faith attendant called us back to the prayer stones for the return blessing. At the second threshold two hands waited for us. First the clay counter, given up into a Balance clerk's palm; she read its number, set it against her slate, and struck the route closed. Then the washing: the dust of the open rinsed from the hands and face in a shallow bowl, the water darkening with it. Behind us, another Faith attendant carried the covered dish over Mara's folded grey shawl between two Shield wardens. And over each of us the first attendant spoke.

"What has touched the open returns under shadow."

We answered. "Under shadow, we return."

We re-entered in single file, and the ceiling came back like a hand over the skull. Relief loosened my shoulders before I could stop it. At evening prayer I thanked God for setting the Mountain over the spring. I fell asleep certain the desert had flashed for me alone.

> — Flashed for me alone. Listen to the boy: he thought God and a whole desert could pick him out of a party.
>
> — Boys do, and it does none of us any harm to have believed it once. Enough for today. You have given me more than a day's worth, and I have an old man's need to sit with a thing before I take the next of it.